STATE SCAN

PUNJAB: WEATHER-BEATEN WHEAT *PG 16*

MAHARASHTRA: THE TCS SCANDAL *PG 20*



PTI

BIG BOOTS Nitish Kumar handing off the reins to Samrat Choudhary at the NDA legislators' meet, Patna, Apr. 14

▶ BIHAR

WEIGHTY CROWN FOR THE NEW SAMRAT

The Nitish era ends. Samrat Choudhary inherits the crown and—as Bihar's first BJP CM—also its complex riddles

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

IT'S A HISTORIC CHANGE OF GUARD. For 20 years, barring a brief interlude of 278 days in 2014-15, Nitish Kumar had made the helm of governance his own space. On April 15, as Samrat Choudhary took oath as Bihar's 24th chief minister, the state crossed a threshold it had long approached. For the first time, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is in charge of the state. In material and symbolic terms, an epoch has ended, and another perchance begun. The 'Nitish way' was built around soft-spoken but canny politics: a flair for coalition-building, calibrated social arithmetic, an ability to balance opposites. Will that end?

Yes and no. The latter is on view presently, as the change of guard gets presented with the elements of continuity, rather than disruption, in the foreground. Once his exit was scripted, it's Nitish who gestured at his preferred successor—and the BJP found wisdom in accepting it. On April 14, at the ruling coalition's legislature party meeting, Ni-